

Testing grounds

Dear Karan,
Once upon a time there was this wonderful magazine called CHIP. Every month I would anticipate the arrival of a new issue packed with useful information and a CD full of great software. I was filled with trepidation when I heard that CHIP was going to be replaced with a new magazine. I comforted myself by saying that it was the same people who were behind the new magazine, but when I bought the first issue of Digit it was my worst nightmare come true. I found that the paper quality of the magazine had gone down. The anti-virus software comparison was very superficial—I expected better from you. The Playware CD had very few games, and the tutorials and software on the Mindware CD were no good. I could go on and on but I'll stop here. Earlier I used to buy every issue of CHIP without a second thought, but I'll think twice before I buy the next issue of Digit.

Your former fan,

MANOJ JOHN ZACHARIAH

Via e-mail

digit

Dear Manoj,

Wow! That's a long list of complaints, but let's take things one at a time.

Quality of paper: It is still 160 GSM for our cover and 60 GSM for the magazine pages. And we print them at the same printing press too. Superficial testing: We did test more anti-virus products than we did in the previous anti-virus test. We now included testing for features such as e-mail scanning, checked for cleaning of the 10 most prevalent viruses and more. You could find the detailed test process and reviews on the Mindware CD. Going a step further, where else would you get 50 products tested across five categories every month?

Too few games in Playware CD: Perhaps, but we keep receiving complaints that with eight or nine games every month, we are too gaming oriented. CD Tutorials: We've included an exclusive free tutorial from Gurukul Online (Windows 2000 for end-users) in the current CD.

Clearly, however, as you have mentioned in the case of the software on the CD, there are several improvements that we need to make. Your continuous feedback and constructive criticism will only help us improve as we grow. So keep it coming.

Duty free

Dear Digit,

I want to draw your attention to an absurd situation. In the US, a Geforce2 GTS card costs a little more than Rs 11,000. The same is priced at Rs 20,000 in India. That's a huge difference! What exactly is going on? I can understand a difference of a couple of thousand rupees, but this is ridiculous. This price puts this card way out of the reach of people like me. What is the reason for this disparity and why are we in India forced to pay so much more?

SHRIPAD KUDTARKAR

Via e-mail

digit

Dear Shripad,

Yes, it is quite absurd. The high prices, especially for certain types of products like graphics cards, are primarily due to additional duties that are levied at the time of import. The duties add up to an increase of approximately 35 per cent on the original price. Which is why a laptop that is available in the US for \$2,000 (about Rs 94,000) would end up costing you about Rs 1,75,000 in India.

Duties are intended to protect the interests of the local industry, but what really ends up happening is that because of the speed of change in hardware technology, it becomes impossible for most Indian manufacturers to compete. Which leaves us paying through our nose for products that are not manufactured in India.

Anybody got a solution? Tell us.

Send your letters marked
'Readers Letters' to the
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Goof Ups

■ The technology-savvy Lokesh informs us rightly that the graphics processor for the Xbox is not NV20 as we'd mentioned, but NV25.

■ Mandeep Mehta is concerned about the value of a scanner we recommended in the decision maker—the HP Scanjet 6350C (the most expensive scanner)—for the price-conscious. Oops...it should have been Acer Scan-Prisa 640U for the budget segment and HP Scanjet 5300 in the mid-range segment

Notice any goof-ups? Write to
goof@jasubhai.com

Short Bytes

Back to the future

Dear Digit,

The five major changes in Indian history:

Congress to BJP

Corruption to Tehalka

Shah Rukh to Hrithik

Azharuddin to Ganguly

CHIP to Digit

AVIJEET MOHANTY

Via e-mail

In the 'write' frame

Dear Digit,

As this is the beginning of a new phase, I think it is appropriate for Digit to start a section in which its readers can also contribute their articles and not just letters and pieces for Backbyte. This will help make Digit more interactive and interesting to readers.

DAVINDER OBEROI

Via e-mail ■

Dear Davinder,

Why don't you make a start by writing for Digit Dialogue, the quarterly newsletter for our subscribers. E-mail your articles to: dialogue@jasubhai.com